“My spouse should make me happy.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Romantic stories may suggest that finding the right spouse ends loneliness and unhappiness. Growing up with little comfort can leave you longing for a partner who will finally meet every need. Stress, disappointment, or losing touch with friends and interests can make your marriage carry more of your emotional life than one relationship can hold.

What Scripture teaches

Marriage is meant to include love, care, companionship, and shared responsibility. Wanting affection and fair treatment is reasonable. But a spouse cannot provide lasting happiness at every moment or meet every emotional need. Scripture honors marriage while also pointing us toward God, wise relationships, and our own daily choices. The guidance in Pearls calls us to treat others as we wish to be treated and to speak gently. Taking responsibility for some sources of joy does not excuse a spouse’s neglect or harmful behavior.

> *“Rejoice in the Lord always. I will say it again: Rejoice!”* (Philippians 4:4).

Also see

> “In everything, then, do to others as you would have them do to you. For this is the essence of the Law and the Prophets” (Matthew 7:12).

> “A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger” (Proverbs 15:1).

> “‘For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife, and the two will become one flesh.’ So they are no longer two, but one flesh. Therefore what God has joined together, let man not separate” (Mark 10:7–9).

> “Rest in God alone, O my soul, for my hope comes from Him. He alone is my rock and my salvation; He is my fortress; I will not be shaken” (Psalm 62:5–6).

Common self-statements

- If I feel unhappy, my spouse is failing me.
- I should not have to find enjoyment outside our time together.
- A good spouse would always make me feel special.
- My mood depends entirely on what my spouse does.
- If marriage takes work, something must be wrong.
- My needs matter, so my spouse should meet all of them.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Turning a reasonable wish for care into a demand for constant happiness.
- External control: Giving another person complete responsibility for your emotional life.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Judging the marriage as bad whenever you feel unhappy.
- Mental filter: Noticing disappointments while overlooking care, support, or other sources of meaning.

Challenging questions

- What care can I reasonably ask of my spouse, and what am I asking one person to provide alone?

- Have I clearly asked for the specific behavior I want?
- Have I ever felt unhappy even when my spouse was caring?
- Which friendships, activities, habits, or spiritual practices support my well-being?
- Can I appreciate love without requiring my spouse to manage every feeling?
- What is one step I can take today without waiting for my spouse to change?

Truth summary

> I can expect love, respect, and effort in my marriage without expecting my spouse to keep me happy all the time. My feelings have many influences. I can ask clearly for care, contribute to our relationship, and build joy through God, friendships, meaningful activities, and healthy daily habits.

Selected Scripture references draw on Pearls, "Marriage" (pp. 240–241) and "Marriage Guidance" (pp. 242–244), with other passages selected for this belief. Quotations use the BSB.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Marriage
- Marriage Guidance
- Communication
- Joy
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Marriage

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Love Take Me Over — Steven Curtis Chapman
Receiving God's love can shape loving action instead of fear or performance.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

What You Want — Tenth Avenue North
Following God involves trust and surrender without needing control of every outcome.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My spouse should make me happy"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My spouse should make me happy." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Which needs can I fairly ask my spouse to meet?
- ☐ Did I ask clearly for the care I want?
- ☐ What else influences my mood?
- ☐ Where else can I find connection and meaning?
- ☐ Can I value love without demanding constant happiness?
- ☐ What helpful step can I take today?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I can ask for care without demanding constant happiness.
- ☐ My spouse matters deeply, but is not my only source of meaning.
- ☐ I can take one helpful step for my well-being today.
- ☐ Love includes mutual effort and realistic expectations.
- ☐ My needs deserve clear, respectful words.
- ☐ Disappointment does not erase every good part of our marriage.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Philippians 4:4
  "Rejoice in the Lord always. I will say it again: Rejoice!"
- ☐ Matthew 7:12
  "In everything, then, do to others as you would have them do to you. For this is the essence of the Law and the Prophets."
- ☐ Proverbs 15:1
  "A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Sources of well-being: Record one caring interaction, one action you took for yourself, and your mood before and after. Include disappointments honestly.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  A personal reminder based on James 1:19: "Sarah can practice being quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger."
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Marriage Guidance" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose exercises you can do safely. If there is coercion, violence, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying joint exercises.

- [ ] Try one meaningful activity independently. Beforehand, predict your enjoyment from 0–10. Spend 20 minutes on it and record your actual enjoyment.
- [ ] Make one specific request. At a calm time, ask for something doable, such as ten minutes together without phones. Record the response without treating it as a verdict on your worth.
- [ ] Reconnect with one supportive person. Arrange a brief call or walk. Notice whether support can come from more than one relationship.
- [ ] Offer one small act of care freely. Choose something you can give without using it as a test or demanding an immediate return.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My spouse should make me happy": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One source of well-being
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My spouse should make me happy.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You for the gift of companionship and for Your love that reaches beyond any one relationship. Help me ask honestly for care, love my spouse wisely, and take responsibility for the steps I can take toward a meaningful life. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

“My marriage will never get better.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Repeated arguments, broken promises, betrayal, or years of feeling alone can make hopelessness understandable. You may have tried hard without seeing lasting change. Depression, exhaustion, or memories of an unhappy family can make the future look like a fixed continuation of the past.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture offers hope and practical guidance without promising that every marriage will recover. A gentle answer, careful listening, and truthful action can change some patterns. You can work on your part, ask for help, and look for sustained evidence of change. You cannot make your spouse become willing, honest, or safe. Hope means remaining open to what can change while facing what is happening now; it does not require ignoring ongoing harm.

> *“If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone”* (Romans 12:18).

Also see

> “A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger” (Proverbs 15:1).

> “He who answers a matter before he hears it— this is folly and disgrace to him” (Proverbs 18:13).

> “Let your gentleness be apparent to all. The Lord is near” (Philippians 4:5).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

Common self-statements

- Nothing we try will matter.
- We had another argument, so we have made no progress.
- The past proves the future is hopeless.
- If change were possible, it would have happened already.
- I have to fix the marriage by myself.
- Seeking help would only confirm that we have failed.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Treating a feared future as a settled fact.
- Overgeneralization: Turning repeated disappointments into an absolute prediction.
- Discounting change: Dismissing small, sustained improvements because everything is not solved.
- Excess responsibility: Assuming one person can repair a two-person relationship.

Challenging questions

- What evidence supports my fear, and what evidence would show even a small change?
- Have we tried a different approach consistently, rather than repeating the same argument?
- What is within my influence, and what belongs to my spouse?
- Is there willingness, accountability, and follow-through from both of us?
- Would private professional guidance help me assess our options?

• Can I choose a wise next step without predicting the entire future?

Truth summary

> I do not know that my marriage will never improve. Some patterns may change with willingness, practice, accountability, and appropriate help. I can take a wise step and observe what happens. Improvement is not guaranteed, and I am not responsible for making my spouse change. My life can still contain support, purpose, and hope.

Selected Scripture references draw on Pearls, "Marriage" (pp. 240–241) and "Marriage Guidance" (pp. 242–244), with other passages selected for this belief. Quotations use the BSB.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Marriage
- Marriage Guidance
- Hopeless
- Guidance
- Peace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Marriage

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Glorious Unfolding — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's story continues beyond a painful or confusing chapter.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Even If — MercyMe
Trust in God need not depend on receiving the particular miracle we want.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My marriage will never get better"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My marriage will never get better." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What small change would I recognize?
- ☐ What have we tried consistently?
- ☐ What can I influence?
- ☐ Is there mutual willingness and follow-through?
- ☐ What help would support a wise decision?
- ☐ What is my next step, rather than my final prediction?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ The future is uncertain, rather than already decided.
- ☐ One argument does not measure every part of our progress.
- ☐ I can evaluate consistent actions instead of promises alone.
- ☐ I am responsible for my choices, not my spouse's choices.
- ☐ Getting help can be a constructive next step.
- ☐ My well-being matters even while the marriage is uncertain.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Romans 12:18
  "If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone."
- ☐ Proverbs 15:1
  "A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger."
- ☐ Proverbs 18:13
  "He who answers a matter before he hears it— this is folly and disgrace to him."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Small-change record: Define one observable change, record whether it occurs, and note whether it lasts. Record setbacks as well as improvement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  A personal reminder based on James 1:19: "Sarah can practice being quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger."
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Marriage Guidance" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose exercises you can do safely. If there is coercion, violence, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying joint exercises.

- [ ] Choose one low-conflict pattern to change. For one week, try a calm greeting or a brief practical check-in. Predict the result first, then record what actually happens.
- [ ] Define what improvement would look like. Replace "everything must be better" with one measurable sign, such as taking turns speaking for five minutes without insults.
- [ ] Seek a private consultation. Discuss your concerns and whether joint counseling is appropriate. If you fear retaliation, seek private support before proposing joint exercises.
- [ ] Review the week's evidence. List helpful behavior, unchanged problems, and harmful behavior separately. Do not count promises as completed change.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My marriage will never get better": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One observable change or setback
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My marriage will never get better.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

God of hope, meet me in my disappointment. Give me courage to face the truth, wisdom about the next step, and strength to seek help. Keep me from both hopeless certainty and false promises. Help me remember that my life matters to You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

“If my spouse loved me, they would know what I need.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Early experiences of being overlooked can make having to ask feel painful or humiliating. Romantic messages may teach that true love should understand without words. Different family habits, indirect hints, and previous disappointment can lead you to wait silently and then interpret an unmet need as proof of not being loved.

What Scripture teaches

Love includes attention and responsiveness, but it does not give a spouse the ability to read your mind. Pearls encourages listening before answering, timely words, and gentle speech. Clear requests give your spouse useful information; they do not make the care less meaningful. You can ask, listen to the response, and evaluate follow-through. Repeated dismissal after clear requests is important information and should not be explained away as your failure to communicate.

> *“He who answers a matter before he hears it— this is folly and disgrace to him”* (Proverbs 18:13).

Also see

> “A man takes joy in a fitting reply— and how good is a timely word!” (Proverbs 15:23).

> “Pleasant words are a honeycomb, sweet to the soul and healing to the bones” (Proverbs 16:24).

> “Instead, speaking the truth in love, we will in all things grow up into Christ Himself, who is the head” (Ephesians 4:15).

> “My beloved brothers, understand this: Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger” (James 1:19).

Common self-statements

- I should not have to ask.
- If I tell them, it will not count.
- They know exactly what I need and are choosing to ignore it.
- A loving spouse would notice every hint.
- Asking makes me needy.
- If they guess wrong, they do not care.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming your spouse already knows what you have not explained.
- Emotional reasoning: Treating the pain of being missed as proof that you are unloved.
- Hidden rules: Measuring love against an expectation you have not shared.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing requested care is worthless compared with spontaneous care.

Challenging questions

- Did I make a direct request, or hope that a hint would be enough?
- Could my spouse understand the situation differently?

- Would I expect myself to know every unspoken need my spouse has?
- Can love motivate a response after an honest conversation?
- What specific action would help, and when would it be useful?
- What happens when I ask clearly and respectfully, and is that response part of a repeated pattern?

Truth summary

> Being loved does not mean being understood without words. I can name my feelings and ask for a specific action. A caring response after I ask still counts. I can listen to my spouse's needs too, while taking repeated dismissal of my own needs seriously.

Selected Scripture references draw on Pearls, "Marriage" (pp. 240–241) and "Marriage Guidance" (pp. 242–244), with other passages selected for this belief. Quotations use the BSB.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Marriage
- Marriage Guidance
- Communication
- Love, For Others

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Marriage

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

Speak O Lord — Keith and Kristyn Getty
Receive God's Word with humility and allow truth to reshape thought and action.

Jesus — Chris Tomlin
Jesus is present in suffering and is greater than the circumstances we face.

What a Friend We Have in Jesus — Keith and Kristyn Getty
This classic hymn invites direct, honest prayer with the Savior who carries our burdens.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If my spouse loved me, they would know what I need"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If my spouse loved me, they would know what I need." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Did I ask directly or only hint?
- ☐ Could my spouse understand this differently?
- ☐ Can either of us read the other's mind?
- ☐ Can requested care still be sincere?
- ☐ What specific action would help me?
- ☐ How does my spouse respond when I ask clearly?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Asking clearly gives love a practical direction.
- ☐ My spouse may care and still misunderstand me.
- ☐ Care offered after a request can be sincere.
- ☐ I can replace a hint with one doable request.
- ☐ My needs matter, and so does my spouse's perspective.
- ☐ I can assess the response without guessing the motive.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Proverbs 18:13
  "He who answers a matter before he hears it— this is folly and disgrace to him."
- ☐ Proverbs 15:23
  "A man takes joy in a fitting reply— and how good is a timely word!"
- ☐ Proverbs 16:24
  "Pleasant words are a honeycomb, sweet to the soul and healing to the bones."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Request-and-response journal: Write the need, your exact request, your prediction, and the response. Separate what your spouse said or did from what you inferred.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  A personal reminder based on James 1:19: "Sarah can practice being quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger."
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Marriage Guidance" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose exercises you can do safely. If there is coercion, violence, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying joint exercises.

- [ ] Turn one hint into a clear request. Try: "I feel disconnected. Would you sit with me for ten minutes after dinner?" Choose your own words and a suitable time.
- [ ] Check understanding. Ask your spouse to tell you what they understood, then clarify kindly rather than testing them.
- [ ] Invite a request in return. Ask, "What is one thing that would help you this week?" Listen before explaining or defending.
- [ ] Compare prediction with outcome. Rate "If I ask, the care does not count" before and after the conversation. Note evidence without forcing a positive conclusion.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If my spouse loved me, they would know what I need": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One clear request or listening step
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If my spouse loved me, they would know what I need.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, help me speak the truth with love and listen with patience. Give me courage to name my needs plainly and humility to understand my spouse's needs. Help us turn care into clear, respectful action. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

“I married the wrong person.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Painful differences, unmet expectations, betrayal, or comparison with other couples may lead you to question your choice. Believing that there is one flawless match can turn ordinary disagreements into evidence of a permanent mistake. Sometimes this thought also points to serious incompatibility or harm that deserves careful attention.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture presents marriage as a serious bond and calls people to kindness, truthful speech, and thoughtful choices. It does not teach that a good marriage requires a flawless spouse or that every difficult marriage was a mistake. Rather than settling the whole relationship with one label, examine specific patterns, responsibilities, and possibilities for repair. Commitment does not excuse cruelty, and this card cannot decide whether a marriage should continue. Serious betrayal, coercion, or violence calls for private, informed help.

> *“‘For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife, and the two will become one flesh.’ So they are no longer two, but one flesh. Therefore what God has joined together, let man not separate”* (Mark 10:7–9).

Also see

> “In everything, then, do to others as you would have them do to you. For this is the essence of the Law and the Prophets” (Matthew 7:12).

> “A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger” (Proverbs 15:1).

> “Be kind and tenderhearted to one another, forgiving each other just as in Christ God forgave you” (Ephesians 4:32).

> “If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone” (Romans 12:18).

Common self-statements

- The right person would never disappoint me.
- Our differences prove that we should never have married.
- Another spouse would solve all these problems.
- I made one choice that ruined my whole life.
- I must either deny the problems or leave immediately.
- Because I regret something, everything about our marriage is wrong.

Common logical errors

- Global labeling: Replacing a detailed assessment with the single label “wrong person.”
- Idealized comparison: Comparing real life with an imagined partner or another couple’s public image.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Assuming a marriage must be effortless or entirely mistaken.
- Counterfactual certainty: Assuming you know how life with someone else would have turned out.

Challenging questions

- Which specific behaviors or differences concern me?

- Am I comparing my spouse with a real person or an ideal picture?
- Which problems are negotiable, and which involve safety, honesty, or basic values?
- Is there mutual willingness to take responsibility and change?
- What do I need to understand before making a major decision?
- Can I replace a sweeping label with an accurate description of the problem?

Truth summary

> The thought "I married the wrong person" does not by itself settle what my marriage means or what I should do next. I can assess the actual problems, consider both strengths and harms, and seek wise help. Imperfection does not prove a mistake, and commitment does not require pretending that serious harm is acceptable.

Selected Scripture references draw on Pearls, "Marriage" (pp. 240–241) and "Marriage Guidance" (pp. 242–244), with other passages selected for this belief. Quotations use the BSB.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Marriage
- Marriage Guidance
- Guidance
- Forgive
- Communication

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Marriage

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

Broken Things — Matthew West
God can work through imperfect people without waiting for them to become flawless.

Do It Again — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's repeated gifts and new mercies express His continuing love.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ's gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I married the wrong person"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I married the wrong person." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What specific problem concerns me?
- ☐ Am I comparing reality with an ideal?
- ☐ Is this negotiable, or a serious concern?
- ☐ Is there mutual responsibility?
- ☐ What guidance do I need?
- ☐ What description is more accurate than "wrong person"?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Specific facts help more than a sweeping label.
- ☐ An imagined perfect partner is not a fair comparison.
- ☐ A difficult season does not explain the whole marriage.
- ☐ Safety, honesty, and mutual responsibility matter.
- ☐ I can seek wise guidance before a major decision.
- ☐ I can face serious problems without denying every good thing.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Mark 10:7–9
  "'For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife, and the two will become one flesh.' So they are no longer two, but one flesh. Therefore what God has joined together, let man not separate."
- ☐ Matthew 7:12
  "In everything, then, do to others as you would have them do to you. For this is the essence of the Law and the Prophets."
- ☐ Proverbs 15:1
  "A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Specific-problem worksheet: Replace "wrong person" with "The behavior or difference concerning me is..." Record its frequency, impact, and what would need to change.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  A personal reminder based on James 1:19: "Sarah can practice being quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger."
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Marriage Guidance" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose exercises you can do safely. If there is coercion, violence, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying joint exercises.

- ☐ Describe one problem without a label. Write what happened, how often, and what it affected. Separate facts from judgments about the whole person.
- ☐ Test a modest repair if it is safe. Choose one negotiable issue, make one clear request, and record whether your spouse follows through.
- ☐ Check the comparison. Write what you actually know about the alternative life you imagine and what you are filling in without evidence.
- ☐ Arrange private guidance. Bring a balanced record of strengths, recurring difficulties, and serious concerns to a qualified counselor. Avoid rushing a major decision to relieve one difficult evening.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I married the wrong person": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One specific fact or wise step
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I married the wrong person.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, give me clarity about my marriage. Help me see my spouse and myself honestly, without idealizing, condemning, or denying harm. Guide my decisions through truth, wise counsel, and love. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

“I can't be loved or happy without my spouse.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

A close marriage can become central to your sense of belonging. Fear of abandonment, bereavement, separation, betrayal, or past rejection may make life without your spouse seem unbearable. Isolation and giving up friendships or interests can make one relationship feel like your only possible source of love.

What Scripture teaches

The Bible honors the deep bond of marriage and also shows that a meaningful life is possible outside it. In Pearls, 1 Corinthians 7:8–9 recognizes unmarried life, and 1 Corinthians 7:39 acknowledges life and choices after a spouse’s death. God draws near to the brokenhearted. Losing a relationship can bring profound grief, but it does not erase your worth or your capacity to receive love, companionship, and moments of joy. Healing takes time, and you do not have to force yourself to feel happy.

> *“The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit”* (Psalm 34:18).

Also see

> “Now to the unmarried and widows I say this: It is good for them to remain unmarried, as I am. But if they cannot control themselves, let them marry. For it is better to marry than to burn with passion” (1 Corinthians 7:8–9).

> “A wife is bound to her husband as long as he lives. But if her husband dies, she is free to marry anyone she wishes, as long as he belongs to the Lord” (1 Corinthians 7:39).

> “Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content with what you have, for God has said: ‘Never will I leave you, never will I forsake you.’” (Hebrews 13:5).

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:38–39).

Common self-statements

- Without my spouse, nobody could love me.
- If I am alone, my life has no meaning.
- I could never enjoy anything again.
- I must accept anything to keep this relationship.
- Needing support means I cannot cope.
- Being separated or widowed makes me incomplete as a person.

Common logical errors

- Catastrophizing: Turning feared loss into certainty that life can contain nothing good.
- Exclusive-source thinking: Treating one person as the only possible source of love.
- Emotional reasoning: Taking today’s grief or fear as a prediction of every future day.
- Conditional worth: Making your value depend on keeping a particular relationship.

Challenging questions

- Does missing my spouse mean I am incapable of receiving love from anyone else?
- Who has cared for me at other times in my life?
- Can deep grief and a brief moment of comfort exist on the same day?
- What would I say to a friend who had lost a spouse?
- Which relationships or activities could I gently reconnect with?
- Am I accepting harmful treatment because I believe I have no other future?

Truth summary

> My spouse is deeply important, but my worth and capacity to be loved do not depend on one person. I may grieve intensely and still receive care from God and other people. With time and support, meaning and moments of joy can grow again. I do not need to accept harm to remain worthy of love.

Selected Scripture references draw on Pearls, "Marriage" (pp. 240–241) and "Marriage Guidance" (pp. 242–244), with other passages selected for this belief. Quotations use the BSB.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Marriage
- Marriage Guidance
- Loneliness
- Grief
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Marriage

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Good Good Father — Chris Tomlin
God's fatherly love is deeper than human approval or achievement.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I can't be loved or happy without my spouse"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can't be loved or happy without my spouse." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who else has shown me care?
- ☐ Does grief prove I can never feel joy?
- ☐ Can grief and comfort exist together?
- ☐ What would I say to a grieving friend?
- ☐ What support could I accept today?
- ☐ Am I accepting harm because I fear being alone?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Grief does not mean my future is empty.
- ☐ My worth continues when a relationship changes.
- ☐ I can receive care from more than one person.
- ☐ A small moment of comfort does not betray my love.
- ☐ I can ask for support and take one manageable step.
- ☐ I do not have to earn love by accepting harm.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."
- ☐ 1 Corinthians 7:8–9
  "Now to the unmarried and widows I say this: It is good for them to remain unmarried, as I am. But if they cannot control themselves, let them marry. For it is better to marry than to burn with passion."
- ☐ 1 Corinthians 7:39
  "A wife is bound to her husband as long as he lives. But if her husband dies, she is free to marry anyone she wishes, as long as he belongs to the Lord."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

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EVERYONE DOES THESE

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  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
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  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Connection-and-comfort record: Record one person, place, activity, or prayer that offered even slight comfort. Note grief honestly rather than trying to erase it.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  A personal reminder based on James 1:19: "Sarah can practice being quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger."
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
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- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose exercises you can do safely. If there is coercion, violence, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying joint exercises.

- [ ] Contact one safe, supportive person. Ask for a short call, visit, or walk. Predict how alone you will feel afterward, then record the actual result.
- [ ] Try one manageable activity. Choose ten minutes of something meaningful. Rate distress and any comfort before and after; improvement is welcome but not required.
- [ ] Build a small support map. List people and services you could turn to for practical help, companionship, spiritual support, or counseling.
- [ ] Make room for grief and connection. Write one thing you miss and one caring action you can receive today. Consider a grief or separation support group when appropriate.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can't be loved or happy without my spouse": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One connection or moment of comfort
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My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can't be loved or happy without my spouse.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Loving Father, stay near in my fear and grief. Help me receive support and remember that my worth has not disappeared. Give me strength for today and openness to the love and meaning that may grow in time. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.